



Prompt Like a Pro

The first AI skill everyone needs.

Made for the Ones Who Move Different.

— EJOSHI —

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SECTION 01

WHY PROMPTING IS THE FIRST SKILL

Better question, better answer.

The AI didn't write a vague answer because it's broken. It wrote a vague answer because you asked a vague question.

Prompting is the small, learnable skill that turns AI from a curiosity into a tool you actually use. The clearer your question, the sharper the answer. It compounds — a slightly better prompt today is a noticeably better answer; ten slightly better prompts a week is, within a month, a real difference in what AI does for you.

This kit is the calmest way into that skill. Four parts to a strong prompt. Eight worked rewrites you can copy. A few advanced moves for after the basics. A short list of common mistakes and how to fix them. A simple system for keeping the prompts that work.

What this kit assumes

You can type a message into an AI tool. That's it. You don't need an account beyond the free tier of whichever AI you're using. You don't need any background in writing or computer science. You don't need to "be good with AI" to start. The skill is built by doing — and doing the right small things on purpose.

Why this comes before everything else

Most "AI courses" start with the tools. This kit starts with the skill. The reason is simple: tools change, and prompts move with you between them. The exact AI you're using now might not be your favorite a year from now — but the way you ask it questions will be. Prompting is the portable skill. Get good at it, and you stay useful as the tools shift around underneath you.

The Ejoshi promise. Always honest. Built for everyone, not just the people who already know. Free to access. No paywall. No gatekeeping. The future shouldn't be locked behind a paywall.

SECTION 02

THE 4-PART PROMPT FORMULA

Every strong prompt has four elements. You don't need all four every time — but knowing them changes how you think.

1. Role

Tell the AI who to be. This is the most under-used move people are missing. A "patient teacher explaining to a curious teenager" answers a question differently than "a tough editor who hates fluff." The role sets the voice, the level of detail, and what kind of mistakes the AI tries to avoid.

"You are a patient teacher explaining this to a curious teenager. Use one everyday analogy."

When to use it: any time tone matters, any time the audience matters, any time you want the AI to skip explaining things you already know.

2. Task

Say what you actually want, specifically. "Tell me about marketing" is not a task. "Write a 3-sentence summary of why small businesses fail at marketing" is a task. The more specific the verb, the better the output: rewrite, summarize, compare, explain, draft, outline, list, critique, translate.

"Write a 3-sentence summary of how compound interest works."

When to use it: every prompt. The task is the spine.

3. Context

Give the AI the background it needs. Who is this for? What do you already know? What constraints exist? What have you tried? Five sentences of context save you twenty rounds of back-and-forth refinement.

"I run a small tutoring business in a college town. I have \$200/month for marketing and twelve hours a week."

When to use it: any prompt where your specific situation matters — and that's most prompts that matter.

4. Format

Tell the AI how you want the output. "Give me a numbered list" or "keep it under 100 words" or "include one example per point" or "respond as a table with columns for pro, con, and effort." Format constraints reshape the answer dramatically.

"Respond as a numbered list, no more than five items, each under 30 words."

When to use it: whenever the shape of the answer matters as much as the content.

One reusable scaffold. Role + Task + Context + Format. You can drop in or skip any of the four, but you'll notice the answers get sharper as you add more of them. The pros aren't doing anything magical. They're filling in the slots.

SECTION 03

EIGHT WORKED REWRITES

Eight common prompt types, each shown as a "before" and an "after" with a one-line note on what changed.

1. For learning

Before: *"Tell me about photosynthesis."* After: *"Explain photosynthesis to me like I'm starting from zero. Use an everyday analogy. End with a one-sentence summary I could repeat back."* Why it works: role implied (patient teacher), context added (zero starting point), format requested (analogy + summary).

2. For writing

Before: *"Help me write a follow-up email."* After: *"I'm following up with a client who hasn't responded in 10 days about a \$4,000 project quote. My tone is direct but warm. Write three versions: gentle nudge, firm check-in, and graceful close-out. Keep each under 80 words."* Why it works: context (client, \$ amount, timing), task (three versions), format (length + named tones).

3. For a decision

Before: *"Should I take this job?"* After: *"I'm deciding between two offers. Job A: more money, longer commute, less interesting work. Job B: less money, fully remote, work I want to do. I care most about energy at the end of the day. What are the trade-offs I might be underweighting?"* Why it works: context (the two options + the priority), task (trade-offs I'm missing — not "tell me what to do").

4. For planning

Before: *"Make me a study plan."* After: *"I have 14 days until a chemistry final. I've covered material through chapter 6 of 9. I can study 90 minutes per day. Create a 14-day plan with one focus per day. End each day with a 10-minute review of the day before."* Why it works: hard constraints (days, chapters, daily time), structure requested (one focus per day, daily review).

5. For feedback

Before: *"Tell me what you think of this paragraph."* After: *"Read this paragraph. Tell me: (a) what's unclear, (b) what's missing, (c) what's strongest. Keep each answer to two sentences. Be specific. Don't soften it."* Why it works: format (three buckets), task (specific kinds of feedback), tone instruction (don't soften).

6. For debugging

Before: *"This isn't working."* After: *"Here's the error: [paste]. Here's what I tried: [list]. Here's what I expected: [describe]. What's the most likely cause, and what should I check first?"* Why it works: structured context (error + tried + expected) lets the AI focus its diagnosis instead of guessing.

7. For explaining

Before: *"Explain blockchain."* After: *"My parent asked what blockchain is. They use a smartphone but not much beyond that. Explain it in three short paragraphs using an analogy they'd recognize. No tech jargon."*

Why it works: real audience (parent), context (their tech comfort), format (three paragraphs + analogy + no jargon).

8. For pitching

Before: *"Write a pitch for my idea."* After: *"My idea is a calm AI learning brand for families. The audience is parents who want their kids to use AI thoughtfully. Draft a 90-second spoken pitch. Open with a real moment, not a stat. End with a single concrete next step."* Why it works: audience clarity, length constraint (90 seconds spoken = ~225 words), opening rule, closing rule.

The pattern. Notice that every "after" version is longer than the "before." That's the work — and that's why most people get bad AI answers. Five extra sentences of context save you ten rounds of follow-up.

SECTION 04

ADVANCED MOVES

For when the basics feel comfortable. None of these are hard. They're just less obvious than Role/Task/Context/Format.

Chaining

Ask the AI to do step A, then use its own answer as input for step B. Example: *"Step 1: summarize my client list as three customer types. Step 2: now write one outreach email tailored to each type."* You get a more coherent output because step 2 builds on step 1, instead of you doing the connecting work yourself.

Role stacking

Two roles in one prompt. Example: *"You're both a tough business mentor AND a kind older sibling. Give me the hard truth, but soften the delivery."* This is useful when you want substance from one direction and tone from another.

Constraint loading

Add multiple constraints that force a sharper answer. Example: *"Explain it without jargon. Use only one analogy. Keep it under 50 words. End with a question."* Constraints force focus. The first answer is rarely the best; the constrained answer often is.

Negative space

Tell the AI what NOT to do. Example: *"Don't use the words 'leverage,' 'optimize,' or 'unlock.' Don't open with a rhetorical question. Don't include a call to action at the end."* AI defaults are surprisingly cliché — naming what you don't want is sometimes more efficient than naming what you do.

Multi-shot examples

Give the AI two or three short examples of the kind of output you want, then ask it to produce one more in the same style. Example: *"Here are three of my product taglines: [A], [B], [C]. Write five more that match this voice."* The AI matches the pattern in your examples faster than it matches an abstract description of the pattern.

Don't reach for these on day one. Get comfortable with the 4-part formula first. The advanced moves get powerful once the basics feel automatic.

SECTION 05

COMMON MISTAKES (AND THE FIX)

The five mistakes that turn most prompts into shrugs.

Too vague. *"Tell me about marketing."* → Fix: add context and a task. *"I run a tutoring business for high school students. What are three low-cost ways to find new customers?"*

No role set. *"Explain quantum physics."* → Fix: name an audience. *"Explain quantum physics like I'm someone new to it. Use an everyday analogy."*

No format. *"Give me ideas for a side project."* → Fix: shape the output. *"Give me five side-project ideas as a numbered list. Each one in under 25 words."*

Asking for opinion when you wanted a method. *"Is this a good idea?"* → Fix: ask for the method. *"What are 3 reasons this could work and 2 reasons it might not?"*

Treating it like a search engine. *"What's the best laptop for me?"* → Fix: treat it like a thinking partner. *"I edit short videos and want under \$1,200. Here's what I do most days: [list]. What are the trade-offs between Option A and Option B?"*

The honest catch. None of these are stupid mistakes. Everyone makes them at first. The fix is the same in every case: be specific about who, what, why, and how.

SECTION 06

SAVE YOUR BEST PROMPTS

A working prompt is a small reusable tool. The people who get good at AI fast aren't smarter — they keep the prompts that worked.

The simple system

Open any notes app. Make one note called "Prompts." Whenever a prompt gets you a useful answer, paste it in. Add a one-line note: what it's for, when to use it. That's it.

After a month, you'll have ten prompts you actually reach for. After three months, you'll have twenty. The collection is yours — calibrated to how you think and what you do.

Naming and tagging

Give each prompt a short tag at the top: writing / decision / learning / debugging / planning. Optional: a star next to the three you use most. Searchable in a single keystroke.

What to throw out

Anything that needed three rounds of cleanup before it was useful. Anything that depended on a specific moment you can't repeat. Anything that gave a confident wrong answer — those teach you not to trust them, but they don't belong in the save pile.

Why a saved prompt is better than a great one

A prompt you saved is a prompt you can edit. The first version got the AI close. The second version, with one tweak, gets it sharper. The fifth version — after five different uses — is calibrated to exactly how you think. That's the actual goal: not finding the perfect prompt, but building a small library of prompts that get better every time you reuse them. AI fluency isn't a thing you learn once. It's a small habit that compounds.

SECTION 07

TEN PROMPTS TO TRY THIS WEEK

A take-home list. Pick three. Use them this week.

1. "Explain [topic I half-know] like I'm new to it. Use one analogy." 2. "Rewrite this in three versions — more confident, more friendly, shorter: [paste your sentence]." 3. "I'm deciding between A and B. Here's my situation: [context]. What trade-offs am I underweighting?" 4. "I have [X hours] to [accomplish goal]. Build me a realistic step-by-step plan with one focus per day." 5. "Read this and tell me what's unclear, what's missing, and what's strongest: [paste your work]." 6. "Walk me through how to solve [problem] the way you'd teach someone learning it for the first time." 7. "You're a tough editor who hates fluff. Cut this in half without losing the meaning: [paste your text]." 8. "Here's what I'm trying to write [type of thing]. Here's my voice [describe]. Draft a first version under [length] that sounds like me, not like AI." 9. "I'm stuck on [problem]. Here's how I'm thinking about it: [your thinking]. What question am I not asking?" 10. "Compare [option A] vs [option B] for [my situation]. Use a three-column table: pros, cons, effort."

One small habit. Run one prompt a day this week. Keep the ones that worked. Throw out the ones that didn't. By the end of the week, you'll have three or four prompts you'll come back to.

SECTION 08

THE PATTERN BEHIND ALL OF THIS

AI doesn't reward effort. It rewards clarity.

The person who types one short, specific sentence gets a better answer than the person who types three rambling paragraphs. The person who tells the AI who to be gets a sharper voice than the person who just says "be helpful." The person who saves five prompts that work gets more done than the person who tries a new prompt every time from scratch.

It's not about being clever. It's about being clear, and being clear takes practice. This kit is the on-ramp.

If you skim only one thing in this kit, skim the eight worked rewrites in Section 03. Those are the patterns most people miss. Everything else here points back to them. Section 02 explains why they work. Section 04 shows what's next. Section 07 gives you ten to try this week. The whole kit is one idea — clarity beats effort — and ten small ways to practice it.

Start with one. Save the prompts that worked. Come back when you need it.

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